

MORGAN QUINN

WRITING CRAFT

CLASS NOTES

The Wound, the Lie, and the Fear

CHARACTER PSYCHOLOGY IN FICTION

Beliefs That Shape Choices

A working belief can travel across genres.

RECOGNITION

'I only matter when I'm useful.'

CONTROL

'Trusting someone means losing control.'

BELONGING

'If they see what I need, they'll leave.'

Which belief could drive Mara's ambition? More than one can fit.

Wound Lie Fear Behavior

One possible explanation for Mara's protective pattern.

WOUND

Praise at home came mainly when she achieved.

LIE / BELIEF

'I only matter when I'm useful.'

FEAR

'If I stop delivering, I'll be overlooked.'

BEHAVIOR

She accepts extra work and hides her need for help.

A formative event or repeated experience can shape a belief. Context shapes the response.

The Fear Between Belief and Action

Another character helps us test the same framework.

EXPERIENCE

At nine, he saw his father lose the family business after a partner's betrayal.

BELIEF

'Trusting people is how you lose everything.'

BEHAVIOR

He checks every contract, withholds information, and calls it 'being careful.'

What does he expect will happen if he relies on someone?

Common Pitfalls

Specific experience and meaningful choices make the framework useful.

Vague Experience

‘She had a bad childhood.’

Name an event or repeated pattern that shaped this belief.

Explanation Without Action

‘I only matter when I’m useful,’ followed by no revealing choices.

Let behavior test the belief. Self-awareness alone may change little.

Disconnected Backstory

The formative experience never affects a present decision.

Ask which choice becomes clearer once you understand the past.

One Fear, Different Protections

Mara fears being overlooked. Eli offers to help with her workload.

Become indispensable: what might she say or do?

Withdraw first: what might she say or do instead?

How could either strategy make connection or recognition harder?

Today’s Takeaways

Experience shapes a belief. The belief influences what feels risky.

A protective behavior can make sense and still create a cost.

Next session: how a character changes, holds firm, or doubles down.